

A Regular Miracle

A Kolkata school shows special children need not be banished to a different world for their education

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CHILDREN HONE THEIR SKILLS

By Elora Sen

It is a pleasant and warm surprise that greets the visitor to the Akshar school in south Kolkata. Dressed in denim shorts or skirts and colourful T-shirts, children of all ages, capabilities and needs spend hours together in this school. Founded in 1998, Akshar is unique as it was conceived as an inclusive school—one where special children study in a mainstream school along with regular children. With four batches having fared well in the ICSE examinations, the school is confident that its teaching style works.

With between 24 and 27 students in each class, the workload for teachers is multiplied as they prepare different worksheets for children of various abilities. Children with special needs work in classrooms with a co-teacher or special educator till Class VI, and “after that, we assess them to see whether they are able to go with the mainstream, or if they become part of special courses. But never are they detached from regular students,” says school principal Kavneet Khullar.

The school ensures that special children attend classes with regular children so that this helps develop

an understanding between the two. There are 500 students, of whom 20 per cent are special. The school is equipped with laboratories, a library and an audio-visual room, apart from classrooms designed in such a way that all children feel comfortable. The terrace is utilised as a sports field where cricket, dodgeball, football and almost all other games are played. The school also has affiliations with various sports clubs of Kolkata and the students are taken there regularly to play.

“I have seen that normally adults have inhibitions, but the children don’t feel any difference between themselves and differently abled classmates. The friendship is amazing and regular children are never hesitant to take that one extra step for his or her ‘special’ friend,” says Neena Singh, Khullar’s partner in the school. “But we do sensitise parents and if anyone is uncomfortable about their child sharing a classroom with a special student, then we tell them that Akshar is not the place for them,” adds Khullar. The school was set up by the Rajpal Khullar Memorial Trust to introduce an inclusive environment for special children. ■